

News Writing

Invitational B Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

From the given information, write a **news story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **45 minutes**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 871 students enrolled in grades 9-12. Last week when meteorologists announced that temperatures would drop below freezing for the first time this year for five days straight, maintenance workers tested heating units on each of the district's eight campuses to ensure they were working properly. The high school, Evans Elementary and Clint Elementary had units that would run but would not generate any heat. HVAC technicians found major mechanical malfunctions on each of those campuses, including potentially unsafe gas leaks in the furnace units. In addition, one middle school and an elementary school had units that would heat but would emit a powerful odor. Crews tested units for compliance over the summer but otherwise had not run them for an extended period of time since last winter.

After testing and multiple attempts to repair the units in-house and given the age of the equipment, Superintendent Mac Weinberg announced that all HVAC units in the district would need to be repaired or replaced as soon as possible. However, because of the scale of the project and the need to order specific equipment, the project is expected to take six weeks.

Since multiple days of below freezing temperatures have been forecast for the week of Feb. 16-20, Weinberg made the decision to close district schools for that entire week while crews work to make repairs and replace some HVAC systems.

You are writing for the issue of the press to be distributed Feb. 13.

■ **MAC WEINBERG, superintendent**

"This is an unfortunate situation that we wanted to avoid. Our campuses were mostly built or renovated in the late '90s and early 2000s. We knew the heating and air conditioning units throughout the district would need to be replaced soon. We just didn't think we'd have it in the budget this year, so we hoped to get one more year out of some of these older units. That decision has turned out to be a mistake, one that will disrupt our entire district and shut down our operations for a week while we wait for this freezing weather to move through. We simply can't allow students to come to school with no heat when temperatures are in the teens.

"The financial impact won't be as significant because we had already planned HVAC upgrades for next year, which we won't have to do now. Our main concern is the lost learning time. We need students in classrooms, not only so we receive our funding from the state, but also because that's what's best for students. We regret that this situation will cause such a disruption.

"While we will have to make some adjustments, our hope is that most of our activities can continue when possible. Basketball and soccer teams will make arrangements to practice at alternate facilities during the week, and

■ **MAC WEINBERG, continued**

indoor home games will move to alternate sites. In addition, the district has submitted a waiver to the state to determine if it will need to add days to the school calendar to make up for lost class time. We will certainly give up our two bad weather days scheduled for April and May, but we may need to make other arrangements for those additional three days.”

■ **KRISTY KERR, director of maintenance**

“We test our HVAC systems quarterly to ensure they are working properly and up to code. Our last time running each of these units was over the summer. Since we’ve had such an unusually warm winter so far, we haven’t had the need to run the heat yet. When we saw warnings about next week’s cold weather, we thought we’d better run them again, so we don’t have any surprises. The results of those tests couldn’t have been worse. Our maintenance staff and contractors will work overtime to repair and replace these units. In the meantime, we just have to hope that the weather improves. We can’t ask students to wear parkas and gloves to school.”

■ **SARAH BHANDARI, junior**

“We all need to be a little more understanding about the small inconvenience missing school may cause. We have been given a surprise gift of time. I’m going to read, play video games and maybe visit my grandparents in Houston. When else will we get to have a surprise week off? I’m going to put on my coat and enjoy it.”

■ **MOSES CHOI, sophomore**

“I certainly don’t want to be at school when it’s freezing, but this closure is going to cause a significant inconvenience for our family’s schedule. We have a trip to Disney World planned for as soon as school gets out. I also play club soccer in the spring, and any days or minutes they add because of this will cause major problems for me.”

■ **SEBASTIAN LOPEZ, AP Human Geography teacher**

“Taking bad weather days or adding days to the school year won’t give me back the class time we need to cover material before AP tests. This is a huge mistake. It’s not only costing us time and money, but it’s also going to take me away from my own family because I’ll be at school multiple Saturdays offering study sessions to make up for this lost time. I’m not willing to allow my students to miss material that could be covered on the AP Human Geography test. I may try and get permission to host lectures over Zoom while we’re out of school. Of course, we’ll see who shows up for that. The closure better not go beyond the week, or I’ll be looking at a significant impact to my students’ AP test scores.”

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

Invitational B Meet • 2026 News Writing Contest Tips and Sample Story

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judges.

1. Open with the most timely lead, given the current circumstances, probably the future event or events. In this instance, the story will be published before the district closes campuses for a week due to broken HVAC units and below freezing temperatures.

All district schools will be closed next week because of the predicted five days of below freezing temperatures while the district works to repair and replace parts of its HVAC systems.

2. Use direct quotes and use those quotes early in the story. Start with the most important interview to the story. After you introduce quotes, use the transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute the quote. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution ("Weinberg said," not "said Weinberg.") Avoid putting two or more quotes from different people together without placing a transition between them (stacking quotes). Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the story flow, and that the quote does not repeat information revealed in the transition.

transition

Maintenance workers turned on the heat last week ahead of next week's forecast only to find significant equipment malfunctions to the heating units at five out of eight campuses. Units at three campuses would not generate any heat, while two more campuses had units that emitted an unsafe odor.

direct quote

"We knew the heating and air conditioning units throughout the district would need to be replaced soon, but we just didn't think we'd have it in the budget this year, so we hoped to get one more year out of some of these older units," Superintendent Mac Weinberg said. "That decision has turned out to be a mistake."

transition

The repairs and upgrades will take around six weeks to complete. According to Director of Maintenance Kristy Kerr, the district tested HVAC units over the summer and saw no major issues, but they would have discovered the problems sooner if the winter had not been unusually warm.

direct quote

“When we saw warnings about next week’s cold weather, we thought we’d better run [the units] again so we don’t have any surprises,” she said. “The results of those tests couldn’t have been worse.”

3. Use third person. Don’t say “our students” or “our principal” or “Some of our students.” Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say “This idea probably won’t work...” or “The district should ...” without attributing that quote to someone. These statements are personal opinions and cannot be made in a news story.

4. Note how in the earlier example of transition/quote, each quote is its own paragraph. Journalistic writing consists mostly of one- and two-sentence paragraphs.

5. End with a strong quote that wraps up the story.

transition

While Weinberg said cost for the repairs is not a major concern as the project was already planned for next year, Kerr said maintenance crews and contractors will work overtime to repair and replace the HVAC units.

direct quote

“In the meantime, we just have to hope that the weather improves,” she said. “We can’t ask students to wear parkas and gloves to school.”

SAMPLE STORY

All district schools will be closed next week because of the predicted five days of below freezing temperatures while the district works to repair and replace parts of its HVAC systems.

Maintenance workers turned on the heat last week ahead of next week's forecast only to find significant equipment malfunctions to the heating units at five out of eight campuses. Units at three campuses would not generate any heat, while two more campuses had units that emitted an unsafe odor.

"We knew the heating and air conditioning units throughout the district would need to be replaced soon, but we just didn't think we'd have it in the budget this year, so we hoped to get one more year out of some of these older units," Superintendent Mac Weinberg said. "That decision has turned out to be a mistake."

The repairs and upgrades will take around six weeks to complete. According to Director of Maintenance Kristy Kerr, the district tested HVAC units over the summer and saw no major issues, but they would have discovered the problems sooner if the winter had not been unusually warm.

"When we saw warnings about next week's cold weather, we thought we'd better run [the units] again, so we don't have any surprises," she said. "The results of those tests couldn't have been worse."

Because the district facilities will be closed for one week, basketball and soccer teams have scheduled practices at alternate facilities, and any home indoor games have been moved to alternate sites. In addition, the district is seeking a waiver from the state to avoid adding days or minutes to the school calendar to make up for lost class time.

"We simply can't allow students to come to school with no heat when temperatures are in the teens," Weinberg said. "We need students in classrooms, not only so we receive our funding from the state, but also because that's what's best for students. We regret that this situation will cause such a disruption."

AP Human Geography teacher Sebastian Lopez said a significant calendar disruption puts his students' AP test scores in danger.

"This is a a huge mistake," he said. "It's not only costing us time and money, but it's also going to take me away from my own family because I'll be at school multiple Saturdays offering study sessions to make up for this lost time."

Junior Sarah Bhandari said she is looking forward to the additional time off.

"I'm going to read, play video games and maybe visit my grandparents in Houston," she said. "When else will we get to have a surprise week off? I'm going to put on my coat and enjoy it."

While Weinberg said cost for the repairs is not a major concern as the project was already planned for next year, Kerr said maintenance crews and contractors will work overtime to repair and replace the HVAC units.

"In the meantime, we just have to hope that the weather improves," she said. "We can't ask students to wear parkas and gloves to school."